SUIT ESTABLISHMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Feel free to disagree with the bidding which is more or less Standard American, not 2-Over-1.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ESTABLISHMENT LESSON

It's great when you have a suit like A K Q J 10 9, six winners just ready to lead out.
But these suits occur only rarely and then usually in the opponent's hands.
So this lesson is about making winners in suits that are not so robust.
This creating of winners is called "establishing" the suit, or perhaps "setting up" the suit.

Establishing by force:

Sometimes the play will be completely obvious, such as this hand.

The contract is 6NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.

♠ K 10 3
♥ K 7 2
♦ Q J 10 9 8
♣ 4 2



♠ A Q 2
♥ A 5 4
♦ K 6 3
♣ A K Q 7

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 8.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit beckons.
Win the ♥ lead, probably with your ♥A, then play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes their ♦A. That is the only trick you will lose since you can easily reach Dummy's remaining ♦ winners.

Ruffing to establish a suit:

Sometimes Dummy has a long suit which would be useful for discards but you have no high cards in the suit to help establish the suit by force. If you're playing a suit contract you may be able to use ruffs to do the work.

Look at an example of this technique.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♥ A K Q then switches to a trump.

Loser count: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

♠ K 4 3
♥ 8 3 2
♦ A K 9 4 2
♣ J 2

Many Declarers will decide the contract depends on the ♣ finesse, so they will pull trumps, get to Dummy and finesse East for the ♣K. And half of the time they will make their contract. Of course the other half of the time they will go down. A more expert Declarer will try to find a plan that doesn't put all her eggs in one basket.



Look at Dummy's ♦ suit. If the defender's ♦s happen to be split 3 - 3 then two winners can be set up by ruffing. But, you have to be careful with your entries. So you win the trump lead in your hand and pull one more trump, making sure you leave the ♠K in Dummy. If the trumps split 3-2 all will be well. If not then you will have to rely on the ♣ finesse. Leave the last trump out for a little while and work on ♦s. Play ♦ A K 2, ruffing the ♦2 with a high trump. IF both defenders follow suit to all three ♦s then the ♦ 9 4 are now winners. Pull the last trump by leading to Dummy's ♠K and discard your ♣ Q 10 on the good ♦s.

♠ A Q J 10 5
♥ J 9 7
♦ 6 3
♣ A Q 10

If it turns out the ♦s do not split 3-3 you will be in dummy with the ♠K and you can take the ♣ finesse.
Played correctly you will make the contract whenever East holds the ♣K but you will also make it when the ♦s split 3-3.
Two chances are definitely better than one.

Ducking to establish a suit:

Here is a nice suit for you and Dummy to have:

♦ A K 9 7 4 2



♦ 6 3

If you are playing a suit contract, say 4♥, you might well establish the suit by ruffing as you did in the last section. But if instead you are playing a notrump contract you will have to establish the suit by a different method.

The "brute force" technique would work just fine with this situation:
The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ A 3
♥ 9 3 5
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ A 2



♠ K 8 5 2
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ K 4 3

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

Needing 2 more winners you will naturally turn to Dummy's ♦ suit. Since there are two black suit Aces in Dummy you don't have a problem with entries so you just bang down the ♦ A K 9. As long as the suit splits 3 - 2 you will establish plenty of extra winners and you will make 6NT with ease.

BUT,

What if Dummy didn't have those two black suit entries???????

The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 3 2
♥ 9 3 2
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ 3 2



♠ A K 8 5
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ A K 4

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

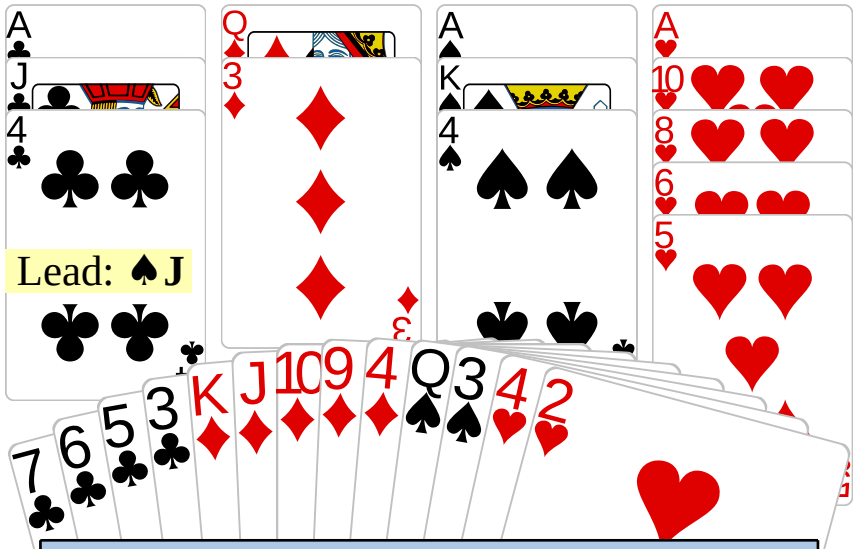
You must find 2 more winners and again, the only hope is Dummy's ♦ suit.
If the suit splits 3 - 2 you can establish 3 winners by playing ♦ A K 9. It won't do you any good though, since you will have zero chance of getting to Dummy to use them.

Try this instead. Win the opening lead in your hand and lead a ♦, playing a small one from Dummy. The defenders will win this trick pretty cheaply, but you don't care. You are hoping that their remaining ♦s are now split 2 - 1, in which case they will fall under Dummy's ♦ A K. And best of all, you still have a small ♦ to lead!

This technique, Ducking, is very useful when Dummy is short (or empty) of entries.

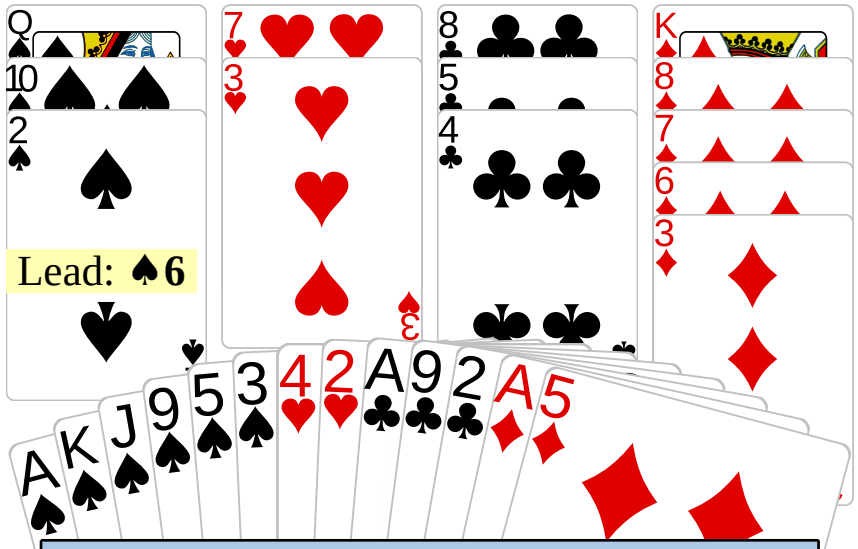
20 Deals are worth more than another 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



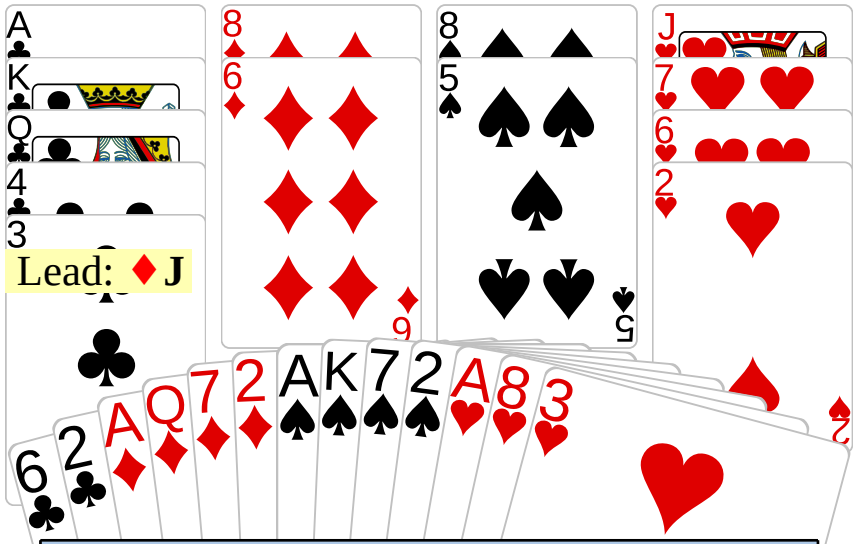
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



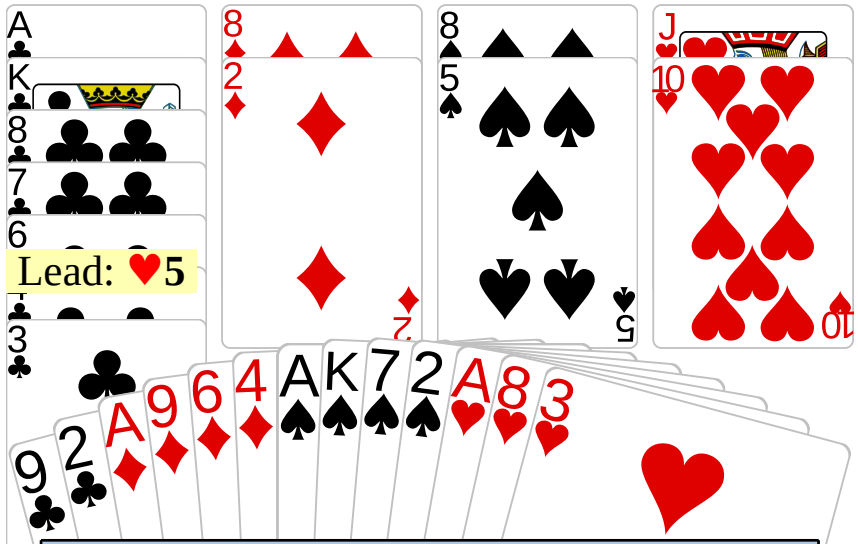
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠6

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥5

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠2

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠2

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 3
♥ 4 2
♦ K J 10 9 4
♣ 7 6 5 3

♠ 7 6 5
♥ K Q
♦ 8 7 5 2
♣ Q 10 8 2



♠ J 10 9 8 2
♥ J 9 7 3
♦ A 6
♣ K 9

♠ A K 4
♥ A 10 8 6 5
♦ Q 3
♣ A J 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠J

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠J.

West plays the ♠5 and you the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 5

You need 4 more winners, and they will come from the ♦ suit once you have knocked out the ♦A. But there is one danger to avoid - if the defenders don't take the ♦A on the first round dummy won't have a ♦ to lead back to your hand. So to make sure you have an entry back you win the first trick with dummy's ♠K, saving your ♠Q.

You start on ♦s with the ♦Q, then the ♦K. Assume the defenders take their ♦A on the second round.

Win whatever they now play and come to your hand with the ♠Q to enjoy your three established ♦s for 9 tricks total.

Establishing the ♦s is the straightforward way to make the contract.

Just don't foul up on your ♠ entry.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 4
♥ K Q 10 6 5
♦ Q J 10 2
♣ K J 6

♠ Q 10 2
♥ 7 3
♦ K 8 7 6 3
♣ 8 5 4



♠ A K J 9 5 3
♥ 4 2
♦ A 5
♣ A 9 2

♠ 8 7 6
♥ A J 9 8
♦ 9 4
♣ Q 10 7 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
2♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♠6

You were counting on West to have a little better hand than that! East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♠6.

North plays the ♠4 and you win with the ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You must find a place for one of those losers and that will mean establishing the ♦ suit. If ♦s split 3-3 that will be pretty easy so you should plan to deal with a 4-2 split. Dummy entries are limited so win the first trick in your hand with the ♠A.

Before you pull any trumps you start on the ♦s by playing ♦A, ♦K and then ruffing a ♦ with the ♠K. South follows to the first two, then discards a ♥.

Play a small trump to dummy's ♠10 (North shows out) and ruff another ♦ with the ♠J.

Dummy's last ♦ is now good. Play a ♠ to the ♠Q, (pulling South's last trump), and discard a ♥ or ♣ loser on the ♦8.

You had to establish the ♦s to make 10 tricks. And once again you had to pay close attention to entries.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 5
♥ J 7 6 2
♦ 8 6
♣ A K Q 4 3

♠ J 4
♥ K 10 5 4
♦ J 10 9 5 3
♣ 10 5



♠ Q 10 9 6 3
♥ Q 9
♦ K 4
♣ J 9 8 7

♠ A K 7 2
♥ A 8 3
♦ A Q 7 2
♣ 6 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦J

North's ♣ bid was Stayman, but he didn't match ♠s. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦J, East plays the ♦K and you win with the ♦A.

West plays low.

East wins with the ♣7.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 8

With the ♦K onside you have 8 tricks, and only need one more. If ♣s split 3-3 you can get 2 extras and make an overtrick. But when you are missing 6 cards they are more likely to be 4-2 than 3-3. Since you only need 4 ♣ tricks you should establish the suit with a duck.

Win the ♦A and play a small ♣ from each hand.

The defense gets a cheap trick in ♣s but you don't mind because you still have a small ♣ for an entry to dummy. You win whatever they return and take the rest of your winners, including 4 tricks in ♣s!

If you had played the ♣s from the top you would have come up one trick short.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

♠ J 4
♥ K Q 9 5 4
♦ J 7 3
♣ Q 10 5

♠ A K 7 2
♥ A 8 3
♦ A 9 6 4
♣ 9 2



♠ 8 5
♥ J 10
♦ 8 2
♣ A K 8 7 6 4 3

♠ Q 10 9 6 3
♥ 7 6 2
♦ K Q 10 5
♣ J

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥5

and you might as well do it at the second trick.

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♥5, dummy plays the ♥10, South the ♥2 and you the ♥3. Dummy wins.

South wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You are very lucky. Apparently North led from ♥ K Q so you won an undeserved ♥ trick. Now, if ♣s split 2-2 you can make 12 tricks! But hold it a minute. If you play dummy's two top ♣s and they **DON'T** split 2-2 you will only win two ♣ tricks and the contract will fail. Instead you should play a small ♣ from dummy right now. The defenders will win the trick easily, but you will win their return and you will still have a ♣ to get to dummy's 6 ♣ winners!

Ducking a ♣ is the only way to make the contract

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 5 ♥ A K 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 4 2	
♠ J 8 3 ♥ J 10 8 5 ♦ K J ♣ Q 9 8 3	N W E S	♠ Q 10 7 2 ♥ Q 9 4 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ J 10 7
	♠ 9 6 4 ♥ 7 3 2 ♦ A 8 5 4 2 ♣ 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and West the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners and dummy's ♦suit is your only hope. **IF** ♦s split 3-2 and **IF** the defenders don't take too many winners in their suit(s) you can establish ♦s by ducking twice.

Win the first ♠. If you hold up they might pocket the ♠ trick and switch to another suit where you only have two stoppers.

Next play a small ♦ from each hand. Win the return (probably a ♠) and duck a second ♦.

If the defenders can only take 2 ♠ tricks now you are home-free since dummy's 3 ♦s are now established.

You had to have the defender's ♠s split 4-3. But in fact you were pretty sure they were going to do so. Since East's ♠2 was probably his fourth-down then he couldn't have a fifth-down.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ J 9 8 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ Q 10 9 6 ♣ K 9 5	
♠ A 7 4 ♥ K 10 9 8 3 ♦ J 5 3 ♣ Q 3		♠ K 6 3 ♥ Q J ♦ A K 4 2 ♣ A 10 6 4
	♠ Q 10 5 2 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ 8 7 ♣ J 8 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠2

West's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s. East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠2.

North plays the ♠J and you win with the ♠K.

South plays low.

North plays low too.

South plays low.

North holds up his ♥A again.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 5

Obviously you need to establish 4 ♥ winners and by driving out the ♥A you can manage that handily. The problem is that dummy has only one sure entry, (the ♠A), and the defenders may be good enough to hold up their ♥A twice.

To assure the contract you should win the first trick in your hand with the ♠K. Then play ♥Q, ♥J overtaking with dummy's ♥K so you can continue establishing the suit while you still have that ♠ entry.

None of the other suits were sitting well so overtaking the ♥ was the way to go.